the Ayeyarwaddy, Sittang, Chindwin, and Mu Rivers. In the second century BCE, clusters of villages slowly evolved into cities that used extensive irrigation systems which created an agricultural surplus that allowed for the specialization of craft production. Archaeological evidence suggests that the city of Beikthano (city of Vishnū) being founded in the first century BCE, and Halingyi shortly thereafter. By the first century CE, the Pyū had established a number of walled cities throughout Upper Myanmar at Beikthano, Mongamo, Śrī Kşetra, Peikhonomyo, Thayekhettaya, and Halingyi that were ruled as kingdoms. In 167 CE, these cities formed a confederation that they called Pyū.

Pyū political power was concentrated at Śrī Kşetra, which was at the mouth of the Ayeyarwaddy River. This helped establish Śrī Kşetra as an alternate trade route from India to China. Prior to the rise of the Pyū, trade passed through northern Myanmar, across the Chindwin River valley to the west. When the mouth of the Ayeyarwaddy River silted up in the eighth century CE, the Pyū moved their capital north to Halin nearer to the trade from India and China.

Excavations undertaken by the Archaeological Survey of Burma suggest that there was a strong Buddhist tradition among the Pyū. Therāvāda Buddhism was most likely introduced to the Pyū via overland and maritime trade routes sometime in the first century CE—the writings of Buddhaghosa, Dhammapala, and others start to appear on inscriptions dating to this period. The Pyū slowly began to convert to Buddhism between the first and second century CE as Therāvāda monks began emigrating from either southern India or Sri Lanka, introducing Buddhism.

Due to the lack of written material, very little is known about the Pyū themselves. What is known about the Pyū comes from two primary sources: the few stone inscriptions found on burial urns and formulaic inscriptions found in Buddhist votive and accounts recorded in the texts of Chinese court chronicles. Chinese historical sources give the first descriptions of the Pyū. The Pyū were first mentioned in Ch'ang Ch'ü's mid-fourth-century text Hua yang kuo chih. In the *Xin Tang shu* (New History of the T'ang Dynasty), Sun Laichen gives a detailed description of the Pyū kingdom and its religion, and mentions the eight or nine fortified cities that the Pyū claimed suzerainty over. Chinese historical records indicate that the Pyū sent tribute missions to the Chinese emperor, accompanied by court dancers